

Armed Mongols in the Oratory of San Giorgio of Padua in the Late Fourteenth Century

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The armed Mongols in the frescoes of Padua's Oratory of San Giorgio by Altichiero remain misunderstood despite several scholarly studies. Beginning with the investigation of contemporary Chinese visual materials, a Persian manuscript, and western and non-western knights' armour, this article analyses how Altichiero represented Mongolian armour and physiognomy. Their appearance in a Franciscan church supported by a family of knights suggests potential religious and political meanings. This article also explores how their political propaganda was visualized in this chapel by considering the military and political context of fourteenth-century Padua.

The fresco cycle in the Oratory of San Giorgio in Padua, adjacent to the Franciscan church of Sant'Antonio, is unusual due to the high number of Mongols appearing on every wall. The Oratory was built as a family chapel by the Lupi family, allies of the ruling Carrara family, and painted c.1379–84 by Altichiero da Verona (c.1330–90). The completion contract of 1384 reveals that Raimondino Lupi commissioned Altichiero, but the project supervision was transferred to Bonifacio Lupi after his death on 30 November 1379.¹ The frescoes' iconography, overtly funerary in purpose and rich in depictions of

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¹ The building date of the oratory is unknown. The completion contract shows Altichiero's involvement and reveals that Bonifacio took over Raimondino's commission. See John Richards, *Altichiero: An Artist and his Patrons in the Italian Trecento* (Cambridge, 2000), 181–2; Louise Bourdua, *The Franciscans and Art Patronage in late Medieval Italy* (Cambridge, 2004), 124–5.

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doi:[10.1017/stc.2026.10061](https://doi.org/10.1017/stc.2026.10061)

saints' lives, represents the family's devotion. However, the presence of the Mongols, equipped with swords and among western knights in Christian settings, has not been fully explained. This article explores the function of these armed Mongols in a Christian funerary chapel.

Discussion of the representation of Mongols in the Oratory is limited.² John Richards noticed the representation of Mongols in San Giorgio and argued that this reflected the artist's own experience of a multicultural society, thereby broadening the setting of the biblical narrative.³ Fabio Tonzar examined different images of Mongols in fourteenth-century Trivenetan art as reflecting broader historical concerns, but regarded Altichiero's representations as simply revealing his exotic taste.⁴ More recently, Anne Dunlop has explored the transmission of images of the Far East and how it permeated northern Italian culture, but she did not focus on the Mongols in the Paduan frescoes.⁵ The visual sources of Altichiero, an analysis of the Mongols' costumes and their specific iconography within the frescoes thus remain insufficiently understood. The representations of them are multifaceted, encompassing positive, neutral and negative perspectives, and cannot be simplified as being merely figures from a different country. In this article, I will concentrate on their identity as 'bystanders' rather than as torturers, providing a fresh perspective on their significance. The Mongol figure is here understood as a hybrid creation, shaped by daily observation, textual imagination and image transmission, serving both cultural and religious functions. The analysis begins with the identification of the Mongols through their physiognomy and costume, comparing the Mongol figures with Chinese visual materials, a Persian manuscript, travellers' accounts, and missionary reports. I then consider the possible transmission of these images from Verona and Florence, and how Altichiero adapted them. Recognizing the military identity of the patrons, I also explore how the Mongols are portrayed as non-western knights. Finally, I situate the representation of the Mongols within the historical context of the patrons' political engagement and Franciscan missionary work in the East, exploring its mnemonic function, and its potential political and religious significance.

² The Mongols, referred to as 'Tartars' in the Latin West, established four khanates in the thirteenth century: the khanate of Cathay (Yuan Dynasty), the Ilkhanate in Persia, the Chagatai Khanate in central Asia, and the Golden Horde in eastern Europe.

³ Richards, *Altichiero*, 208–10.

⁴ Fabio Tonzar, 'L'iconografia degli "altri" nell'arte triveneta dei secoli XI–XIV' (PhD thesis, Università degli Studi di Udine, 2014), 192–8.

⁵ Anne Dunlop, 'Mongol Eurasia in the Trecento', *Convivium* 7 (2020), 114–35, at 114.

THE PHYSIOGNOMY AND ATTIRE OF MONGOLS

In San Giorgio, the figures represented with the typical physiognomy of the Mongols are usually portrayed as wearing a pointed hat and a robe with fitted sleeves, a gathered waist and a loose bottom. Depictions of Mongols (marked by squares) appear in the south wall's *Crucifixion* (Figure 1, no. 1), the upper west wall's *Martyrdom of St Catherine* (Figure 2, nos 2–3), on the middle right of the north entry wall's *Adoration of the Magi* (Figure 3, nos 5–6), and in the upper north-west wall's *Execution of St Catherine*. Other Mongols depicted with pointed hats or Mongolian physiognomy appear among groups in *St George on the Wheel* and *Beheading of St George* (Figures 4–5, nos 8–11).

The most typical feature of Mongol identity is their physiognomy, which has usually been represented with a round face, narrow and upswept eyes, a moustache, a long braid and the wearing of a pointed hat (or turban). This coincides with the description of Tartar slaves

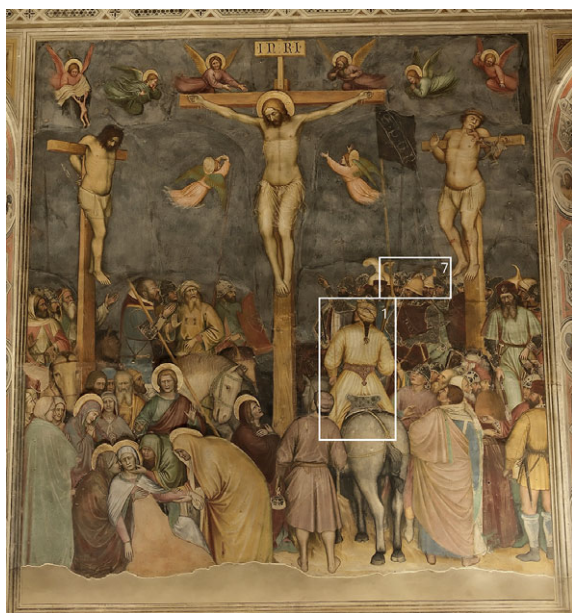


Figure 1. Altichiero da Verona, *Crucifixion*, 1378–84, fresco, Oratory of San Giorgio, Padua. © The author.



Figure 2. Altichiero da Verona, *Martyrdom of St Catherine*, 1378–84, fresco, Oratory of San Giorgio, Padua. © The author.

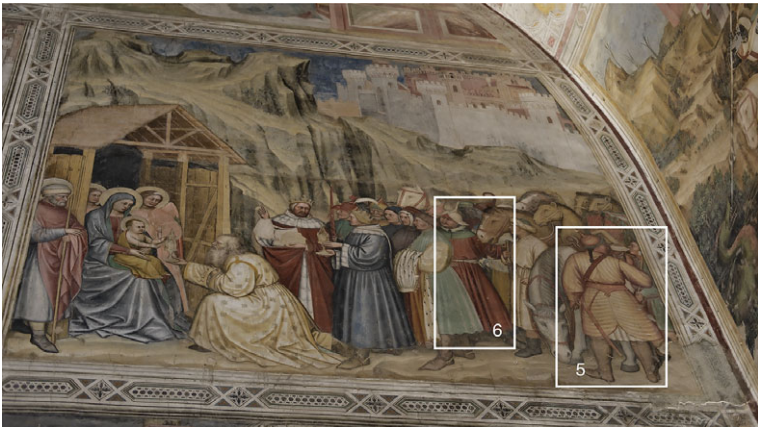


Figure 3. Altichiero da Verona, *Adoration of the Magi*, 1378–84, fresco, Oratory of San Giorgio, Padua. © The author.

made by poets, merchants and in slave contracts in the fourteenth century. The main features of their facial shape are broadness and flatness.⁶ Their visual representation here is therefore clear and realistic, rather than an artistic creation. For Richards, the Asians in these

⁶ See ‘Tartar face’, in Hannah Barker, ‘Egyptian and Italian Merchants in the Black Sea Slave Trade, 1260–1500’ (PhD thesis, Columbia University, 2014), 78–9.



Figure 4. Altichiero da Verona, *St George on the Wheel*, 1378–84, fresco, Oratory of San Giorgio, Padua. © The author.

frescoes, who are shown wearing their modern dress (that is, contemporary with the artist), signified the continuous ‘empirical expansion of the painted world’.⁷ The background and architecture of the scenes might have originated from the Paduan court and their daily life, but Altichiero widened this world by depicting different nations, including Tartars and Turks who could be met in daily life.⁸ Indeed, the painting of this cycle coincides with a period in which Mongols had not completely retreated from Paduans’ daily life and political activities. Altichiero could have seen Tartars himself.⁹ In Venice, records show

⁷ Richards, *Altichiero*, 208.

⁸ Ibid. 209–10.

⁹ ‘Tartars’ were generally known as ‘Mongols’ in the Latin West. It was a created term to refer to Mongols when they had begun to invade the west of Eurasia in the early thirteenth century. Its origins could be the corruption of a nomadic tribe’s name ‘Tatar’, or be a pun on ‘Tartarus’ (hell) to imply the panic in Europe caused by the Mongols. Although William of Rubruck (c.1215–95), travelling to the Mongol empire in 1253, had mentioned that Mongols were Tartars, which anthropology considers as ‘a constituent ethnoracial group (Tartars include Tartar, Karakitay, Kereit, Merkit, Uighur, Mongol, Tangut, Naiman, and Kirgiz)’, the appellation of Mongols was not rectified and continued to be used in the fourteenth century. From a verbal perspective, ‘Tartar’ would gradually become an idiom, with the implication of hell becoming weaker over time. For more details on this, see Geraldine Heng, *The Invention of Race in the*

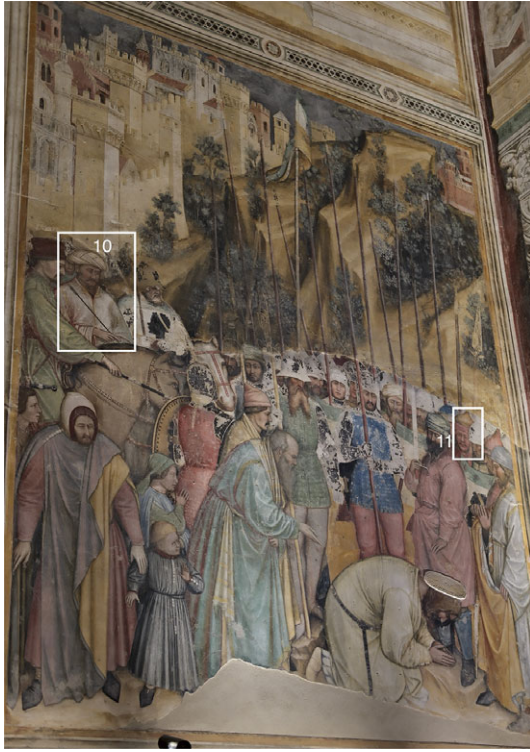


Figure 5. Altichiero da Verona, *Beheading of St George*, 1378–84, fresco, Oratory of San Giorgio, Padua. © The author.

that a transaction involving a Tartar slave took place on 10 September 1366, with three further transactions involving Tartar slaves being recorded in 1372, 1373, 1377.¹⁰ These transactions provide evidence that artists would have had opportunities to observe Tartars in the cities and depict them from real life. The Venetian sculptor Andriolo de Santi (who refurbished a nearby chapel also painted by Altichiero)

European Middle Ages (Cambridge, 2018), 215, 289–90, 383 n. 2. In order to be consistent with the contemporary text, I will use ‘Tartar’ when discussing the historical records, and ‘Mongol’ to refer to the nation.

¹⁰ The documents are in the Archivio di Stato di Venezia, and are published in Ridolfo Livi, *La Schiavitù Domestica nei Tempi di Mezzo e nei Moderni* (Padova, 1928), 324–5.

hired five Tartar slaves for a year for 200 ducats on 29 May 1374.¹¹ In February 1372, Andriolo was hired to refurbish the Lupi Chapel of San Giacomo in the Santo.¹² It is not inconceivable that these Tartar slaves helped with the stonework for the chapel and were in the Santo in 1374 and 1375. The last date of Altichiero's involvement in this chapel's fresco was 1379, but in March 1377 the scaffolding was already prepared for the painter.¹³ Prior to 1377, when Altichiero was designing the fresco, he would have needed to observe the building work. Moreover, before working for the Lupi family in 1377, Altichiero had painted the frescoes of the Sala dei Giganti in the Carrara Palace (famous for its portrait of Petrarch), which he had probably designed by 1374.¹⁴ Thus, it is possible that Altichiero lived in Padua between 1374 and 1375, although there is no direct evidence to prove this. Therefore, it is feasible that Andriolo's Tartar slaves could have been the model for the physiognomy of Altichiero's Mongols in San Giorgio.

Among their recurring features is the long braid, combined with a robe whose style could point to the figure's nation. A remarkable Mongol seen from the back riding a horse can be identified by these two characteristics in the *Crucifixion* (Figure 1, no. 1). The man gazing up at Christ has a braid and wears a turban, a light-yellow robe with narrow sleeves and a loose bottom, and a wide waist belt patterned with golden motifs. Mongols were known for braiding their hair into a single plait that hung down from the back of their head.¹⁵ A Yuan-Dynasty pottery figurine unearthed in Shaanxi shows this hairstyle (Figure 6). Without any other significant facial or hat features, the long braid is one major way to differentiate Mongols from the back from western men's

¹¹ Published in part in Antonio Sartori, *Documenti per la storia dell'arte a Padova*, ed. Clemente Fillarini (Vicenza, 1976) 10.

¹² Louise Bourdua, 'Time-Keeping in Fourteenth-Century Venetian Sculpture: Andriolo de Santi's Absenteeism', *Sculpture* 19 (2010), 102–9, at 105 n. 40.

¹³ Bourdua, *Franciscans*, 113.

¹⁴ Richards, *Altichiero*, 106.

¹⁵ '蒙古人顶正中留发甚长，四周余发分绾二辮，同复合辮为一，垂于脑后。' ('Mongols leave a long lock of hair at the top of their head, while the remaining hair on the sides is divided into two braids, which are then combined into one and hang down the back of the head.'): 赵珙 [Gong Zhao], 蒙鞞备录 [*MengDa BeiLu; The Mongolian Chronicle*], annotated by 王国维 [Guowei Wang] (Shanghai, 1936), 3; author's own translation. In 1221, Gong Zhao was despatched as an envoy of the South Song Dynasty to the Mongolian army encampment in Henan. The author has long been mistakenly identified as 孟珙 [Gong Meng]; the correct author is used here to rectify this error.

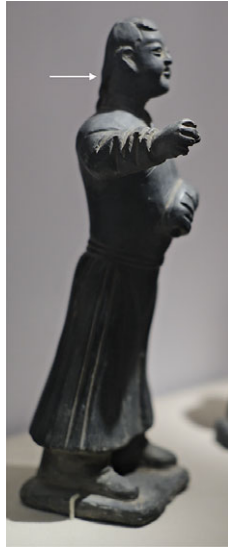


Figure 6. Pottery figurine, Yuan Dynasty (1271–1368), unearthed at Tomb 132 of Jiangqincun Cemetery, Xi'an, Shaanxi province, National Museum of China, Beijing. © The author.

short and curly hair in the Paduan frescoes.¹⁶ Moreover, the style of this figure's robe corresponds to that of an extant Mongolian braided waist robe of the Yuan Dynasty in the China National Silk Museum (Figure 7), although the extant robe has a prominent braided band on the waist, while the fresco either omits this part or has it covered by the belt. In addition, this wide belt has a downward protruding section in the middle, which is different from the more usual narrow belts: no similar extant object has been found in central Asia or China. This difference suggests that Altichiero might have relied on textual descriptions rather than direct observation. Indeed, his depictions correspond to earlier missionary accounts. The Flemish Franciscan friar William of Rubruck (*c.*1215–95) and the Italian Franciscan friar John of Plano Carpini (*c.*1180–1252) both mentioned that the clothing styles of Mongolian women and men were the same, and that 'they wear tunics of buckram, velvet or brocade' which 'are open from top to bottom and

¹⁶ For a possible visual source for the braid, see the next section.



Figure 7. Braided waist robe, Yuan Dynasty, silk tabby with supplementary wefts of gilt thread, 202 × 117 cm, China National Silk Museum (No. 1753), Hangzhou. © 2017 China National Silk Museum.

are folded over the breast'.¹⁷ To a certain extent, Altichiero's representation of the Mongolian robes accords with both the features of Yuan Dynasty representations and western descriptions of Mongols.

In the *Martyrdom of St Catherine*, a Mongol appears at the front of the crowd raising his arm and holding a shield, with his back to the scene (Figure 2, no. 2). The representation of his robe and turban bears a striking resemblance to his counterpart in the *Crucifixion*, but his belt – designed for the carrying of personal effects like a curved sword – is narrow, as commonly seen in Mongolian examples. On the left side of the fresco closest to the wheel, another Mongol is looking at St Catherine (Figure 2, no. 3). He wears a long, red and padded robe, and a red pointed hat with a long braid. At his waist, a curved sword hangs from a thin belt. Another Mongol can be seen from the back on the right hand side of the *Adoration of the Magi* (Figure 3, no. 5). In

¹⁷ Eiren L. Shea, *Mongol Court Dress, Identity Formation, and Global Exchange* (New York, 2020), 81.

contrast to the worshippers who focus their attention on the Christ child, he directs his gaze in the opposite direction towards a man drinking. He wears a pointed hat, a robe with tight sleeves and a wide orange belt holding a sword, but his robe is shorter, just down to the knee. The belt is of the wide type with a protruding part. Another Mongol, wearing a red robe and a pointed hat with four corners, shows curiosity towards the Magis' act of offering (Figure 3, no. 6). His physiognomy suggests that of a Mongol, and his red robe also displays the features of their robes, but the green collar seems an addition. All these Mongols are presented as bystanders, watching the scenes. However, another is depicted as a torturer in the *Execution of St Catherine*: he wears a turban and a long robe, holds the curved sword in his right hand and Catherine's crown in his left.¹⁸

In addition to these prominent figures, Altichiero also portrayed subtle and specific details to suggest other Mongols among the many bystanders. There are two light yellow pointed hats protruding among the faces behind the Mongol seen from the back in the *Martyrdom of St Catherine* (Figure 2, no. 4). In the *Crucifixion*, Altichiero carefully delineated the face of a Mongol wearing a yellow pointed hat immediately behind the knight bearing a SPQR banner, as well as two yellow pointed hats in the background (Figure 1, no. 7). In *St George on the Wheel*, among the soldiers on the right, there is a pointed hat, this time with a square shape (Figure 4, no. 8) and a Mongol face wearing a turban (Figure 4, no. 9). A similar mounted figure with a yellow turban pointing to St George kneeling holds an arrow (Figure 5, no. 10), while a head in the crowd capped with a round hat on the right of his *Beheading* displays the physiognomy of a Mongol (Figure 5, no. 11). These Mongols are all represented as passive onlookers, witnessing the unfolding of the key events of the Christian narrative.

In these scenes, headgear serves as a crucial visual identifier. The pointed hats of the Mongols demand particular attention given their ambiguous origin and potential symbolic function. There is no similar representation or extant object from the Yuan Dynasty or the Near East; however, Altichiero could be imitating the Mongolian noblewomen's official hat. In the official bust portraits of the Yuan Dynasty, the empress wears a tall pillar-shaped hat called *boqta* (Guguguan or

¹⁸ Given the complexity of this theme, I plan to discuss this type of protagonist in a future article. Note that the *Execution of St Catherine* is different from the *Martyrdom of St Catherine* (Figure 2). The former image is not reproduced here.



Figure 8. *Khubilai Khan's Consort* (Chabi), Yuan Dynasty, album leaf, ink and colours on silk, 61.5 × 48 cm, National Palace Museum, Taipei. Open data © 2024 The National Palace Museum, Taipei, CC BY 4.0 @ www.npm.gov.tw.

Gugu hat) (Figure 8).¹⁹ The reproduction of this hat in the China Silk Museum also shows its strikingly tall feature.²⁰ Meanwhile, William of Rubruck described this headdress, *bocca*, as being like ‘the capital of a pillar’ and ‘square above’; the Muslim traveller Ibn Battuta (1304–c.1369) called it a *boghthak* and ‘decked at the apex’ with a peacock’s feather; Franciscan friar Odoric of Pordenone (c.1286–1331) referred to it as ‘the foot of a man’ worn on married women’s heads.²¹ These visual depictions and verbal descriptions confirm that the tall pillar-shaped hat was an actual Mongol headdress. Altichiero seems to have captured the tall feature, transformed the flat top to a pointed apex and put it on a man’s head. These altered hats then become the typical and stereotypical markers of the Mongols in the frescoes.²² Eiren L. Shea has argued that the Mongolian women’s dress was also a symbol of Mongol power and, thanks to the typical hat *boqta*, could be recognized quickly.²³ Indeed, Eleonora Tioli cited an image, evoked by

¹⁹ This headdress is also called *Bocca*, *Botta* or *Bocta* in the missionary accounts.

²⁰ This modern reproduction was made and is displayed in the China Silk Museum, Hangzhou.

²¹ *Cathay and the Way Thither*, transl. Colonel Henry Yule, 2 vols (London, 1866), 1: 131–2.

²² Altichiero also painted a figure with European facial features wearing this tall hat in the *Crucifixion* (1377–9) of San Giacomo Chapel in the Church of Sant’Antonio. Even though the figure has a European face, the pointed hat gives him a Mongolian look.

²³ Shea, *Mongol Court Dress*, 90.

William of Rubruck, that 'from a distance, each [Mongol woman] looked like a soldier, since her *boqta* could be mistaken for a helmet, and the feathers at its top for spears'.²⁴ This description might explain why Altichiero was inspired to represent Mongols with such pointed hats.

However, the turbans of some of the figures (Figures 1, 4, 5, nos 1, 2, 9, 10) display hybrid features, raising questions about Altichiero's visual sources and intentions. These turbans resemble headwear more commonly associated with Central Asia or the Ottoman Turks in the late fourteenth century, yet they are positioned on 'Mongolian' heads. The political context helps to explain this representation. During this period, Ottoman Turks became a violent threat to Christendom, and popes organized several crusades against them in 1363, 1373 and 1375.²⁵ Although turbans were worn by Muslims of all origins, whether Turks, Moors or Arabs, they became the quintessential symbol of Turks.²⁶ Nonetheless, as early as the twelfth century, turbans had appeared in religious visual representation and were associated with distance in place or religious belief.²⁷ As Mongols were distant strangers to Paduans, it became possible for Altichiero to appropriate this religious visual expression.

By integrating a turban with a Mongolian robe and hairstyle, these representations illustrate the hybridity of two eastern nations. The braid and robe are two characteristics attributed to the Mongols. Regarding the robes, William of Rubruck and John of Plano Carpini both recorded that the dress of Mongol men and women was similar and that they did not have distinguishing differences.²⁸ Considering that not all artists were able to witness Mongols in real life, and that the oral and visual sources of Mongolian physiognomy could be vague, it might be possible that artists selected very specific elements of

²⁴ Eleonora Tioli, 'The Khan in the West: The Reception of Mongol Political Power in the Texts and Images of Medieval Latin Europe', in Michele Bacci, Gohar Grigoryan and Manuela Studer-Karlen, eds, *Staging the Ruler's Body in Medieval Cultures: A Comparative Perspective* (Turnhout, 2023), 202–24, at 210.

²⁵ For more detail, see Simone Lombardo, 'A Turkish Affair in the Fourteenth Century: Transformations in the Idea of Crusading through Papal Correspondence (1352–78)', *Crusades* 22 (2023), 245–65.

²⁶ Charlotte A. Jirousek, *Ottoman Dress and Design in the West: A Visual History of Cultural Exchange* (Bloomington, IN, 2019), 104.

²⁷ Ruth Melinkoff, 'Headgear: Holy and Unholy', in eadem, *Outcast: Signs of Otherness in Northern European Art of the Late Middle Ages*, 2 vols (Berkeley, CA, 1993) 1: 57–94, at 60.

²⁸ *Ibid.* 80.

Mongolian clothing, like the *boqta* or the long robes, to distinguish the group from western styles of dress. Furthermore, Altichiero's representation of the robe's collar also shows this hybridity. William of Rubruck recorded that 'the Tartars differ from the Turks, for the Turks tie their tunics on the left, but the Tartars always on the right.'²⁹ Indeed, in the contemporary Chinese painting *Albums of Yuan Imperial Portraits* and the hanging scroll depiction of the emperor and empress entitled *Kublai Khan Hunting*, all the protagonists are shown with robes tied on the right.³⁰ However, frontal details are rare in the frescoes of the Oratory, as are the hairstyles. The only frontal dress represented is that of the torturer in the *Execution of St Catherine*, whose collar is different from the Mongol or Turk. This might point to Altichiero's appropriation of different headgear and clothing details, as he mixed the gender and national features of the hat. Overall, the representation of the Mongols in San Giorgio draws together visual features from diverse sources. This suggests that Altichiero drew on both his own knowledge of Mongols and others' verbal accounts to create a recognizable Mongol.

PRECEDENTS AND THE TRANSMISSION OF IMAGES IN VERONA AND FLORENCE

Although Altichiero's Mongol figures in San Giorgio are highly distinctive, they did not emerge in a visual vacuum. An early visual precedent for the pointed hat appears in the fresco of the St Anthony Chapel in San Fermo Maggiore in Verona, dated to the 1340s.³¹

²⁹ Shea, *Mongol Court Dress*, 81.

³⁰ The hanging scroll was referred to as the *Kublai Khan Hunting*. Its exact date and the identity of the emperor remain debated: see Shouqian Shi, ed., *Age of the Great Khan: Pluralism in Chinese Art and Culture under the Mongols* (Taipei, 2002); Xiaowei Chen, 'The Circulation of Emperor Shizu in a Hunt', *Journal of National Museum of China* 6 (2016), 117–25. *Albums of Yuan Imperial Portraits* and *Kublai Khan Hunting* are preserved in the National Palace Museum, Taipei. For online images of which, see National Palace Museum, online at: <<https://theme.npm.edu.tw/khan/Article.aspx?sNo=03009149&uid=03009128&lang=2>> and <<https://theme.npm.edu.tw/khan/article.aspx?sno=03009223&lang=2>>, accessed 10 September 2025.

³¹ This is the earliest example of this hat that I can find in the extant fresco cycles in the Veneto. See Caterina Gemma Brenzoni, 'Scoperte, restauri e riletture: le cappelle di Sant'Antonio, della Passione e di San Bernardo', in Paolo Golinelli and Caterina Gemma Brenzoni, eds, *I Santi Fermo e Rustico: Un culto e una chiesa in Verona* (Verona, 2004), 221–46, at 221–5.

A person wearing such a hat is listening to St Anthony's sermon. There again, it is a hybrid figure: the artist combined western physiognomy with a Mongolian hat. On the lunette of the west door of San Fermo, Turone di Maxio also painted this pointed hat in 1350 in his *Crucifixion*. Despite the similarity in Altichiero and Turone's works of the pointed hats, narrative format and crowding, this is unlikely to suggest a direct influence from Verona, though Altichiero did work in Verona in the later 1360s.³² It is more plausible that both artists drew from the Tuscan painting format or responded to the same visual representation.³³

Another visual connection exists between Altichiero's fresco cycle in San Giorgio and Andrea di Bonaiuto da Firenze's *Pentecost* in the Chapter Hall of Santa Maria Novella in Florence (Figure 9). Both depict a Mongol seen from behind, observing miracles in Christological or martyrdom cycles. On the day of Pentecost, the Holy Spirit



Figure 9. Andrea di Bonaiuto, *Pentecost*, 1365–7, fresco, Spanish Chapel of the Church of Santa Maria Novella, Florence. © The author.

³² Richards, *Altichiero*, 1–2.

³³ Ibid. 22–4. Turone introduced to Verona complex but well-structured arrangements of crowds, and a diversity of figure types to narrative scenes. The format was associated with Tuscan Giottesque paintings or with the work of Tuscan expatriates with whom he worked in Lombardy and the Veneto.

appeared in the shape of a tongue of fire, with the apostles now able to preach to the nations in their own languages.³⁴ The presence of the Mongol in Bonaiuto's *Pentecost* may suggest the apostles' ability to preach to Mongols and the possibility that the Mongols could be converted. Similarly, Altichiero's fresco cycle could also reflect this expectation of the Mongols' conversion.³⁵ In addition, comparing Florence and Padua, we can observe striking similarities in their depictions of the Mongolian pointed hat, braided hairstyle, long robe and back in the central scene. In the *Martyrdom of St Catherine*, the central Mongol (Figure 2, no. 2) adopts a similar inverted posture to the one in *Pentecost*. Consequently, the *Pentecost* might be a possible visual source for the braid for Altichiero. In contrast, neither William nor Odoric mention either this hairstyle or the hairstyle of a Tartar slave. Furthermore, Altichiero had previously looked to Tuscan models for inspiration when he was transmitting the composition of the silver altar of the martyrdom of St James in Pistoia for his fresco cycle in San Giacomo.³⁶ Chronologically, this is also plausible, for the Florentine fresco was completed only twelve years before Padua.³⁷ Although a direct visual borrowing cannot be proved, the *Pentecost* may have offered Altichiero a compositional and iconographic model, particularly for the rendering of the Mongol's headgear and the view of him from behind.

MONGOL ARMOUR AND SWORDS

The depiction of Mongols with swords in San Giorgio introduces a different perspective: martial presence. The Persian historian Rashīd al-Dīn (1247–1318) provided a foundational source for Mongol military images. His illustrated universal chronicle, *Jamī' al-Tawārikh* ('Collected History', 1314–15, Or. MS 20 Edinburgh) offers detailed

³⁴ Jacobus de Voragine, *The Golden Legend: Reading on the Saints*, transl. William Granger Ryan (Oxford and Princeton, NJ, 2012), 306.

³⁵ See below, in the section entitled 'Mongols as Religious and Political Propaganda', for a discussion of how Altichiero represented the hope that Mongols could be converted.

³⁶ See Louise Bourdua, 'Some Pilgrimage Sources for Altichiero', in eadem and Robert Gibbs, eds, *A Wider Trecento: Studies in 13th and 14th Century European Art Presented to Julian Gardner* (Leiden, 2001), 190–9.

³⁷ Gaia Ravelli, 'L'egemonia degli Orcagna e un secolo di pittura a Santa Maria Novella', in Andrea de Marchi, ed., *Santa Maria Novella. La basilica e il convento I* (Florence, 2015), 157–246.

scenes of Mongolian battles, especially largely accurate images of Mongol soldiers.³⁸ Members of the Mongolian cavalry wear lamellar armour across the whole body, usually holding bows or lances (Figure 10).³⁹ Helmets depicted in these manuscripts often feature an upfolded brim, pointed apex and a protective attachment for neck and ears formed by lamellar armour. These images convey the core elements of Mongol armed attire. A similar iron helmet is preserved in the Hulunbuir (China) Ethnography Museum,⁴⁰ suggesting visual continuity. Moreover, the military actions of western soldiers indicate the distinctive nature of Mongolian helmets: these helmets became recognizable military markers, sometimes applied as a disguise. Thus, after successful Mongol invasions in the thirteenth century, Armenian soldiers imitated Mongolian apparel, especially their hats, to threaten and confuse their opponents into abandoning fighting.⁴¹ The Mamluk governor Izz al-Din Aybak al-Rumi requested a supply of Mongol caps in 1293 to achieve this military disguise.⁴² This confirms that Mongol helmets were both visually distinctive and symbolically powerful, distinguishing the Mongols from other armies.

Strikingly, such helmets are absent from San Giorgio. Whether depicted as riders, witnesses, or as individuals half-hidden amongst western soldiers, the Mongol figures' headgear and clothing do not display the significant features of the iron-made helmets or armour belonging to the Mongols. Rather, the Mongolian clothing represented seems to be that of unarmed men. The style of robe, as mentioned above, is that of the Mongols' daily robes, although the curved swords hanging on their belts may differentiate them from general witnesses. Yet it is clear that the material of the robes has been

³⁸ Sheila Blair, 'Illustrating History: Rashid al-Din and his Compendium of Chronicles', *Iranian Studies* 50 (2017), 819–42, at 820, 835. Rashid al-Din was commissioned by Ilkhanate Khan Ghazan (r. 1295–1304) when the Yuan Dynasty had a close relationship with the Ilkhanate. Chinese illustrations have been considered essential sources for the historical account of China in Rashid al-Din's Compendium of Chronicles.

³⁹ Edinburgh, University of Edinburgh Library, *Jami' al-Tawarikh*, Or. MS 20, fol. 108^v. Lamellar armour is usually made from small iron plates whose shape is like lamellae, or scales, laced into horizontal rows.

⁴⁰ For an image of which, see Hulunbuir Ethnography Museum, online at: <https://www.hlibebwy.com/index.php/home/index/relic_detail?id=26180>, accessed 10 September 2025.

⁴¹ Angus Stewart, 'If the Cap Fits: Going Mongol in Thirteenth Century Syria', *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society* 26 (2016), 137–46, at 138. For further examples of foreign soldiers disguising themselves by wearing Mongol army hats, see *ibid.* 139–42.

⁴² Stewart, 'If the Cap Fits', 142.



Figure 10. *Jami' al-Tawarikh*, Or.Ms.20, fol. 108^v, Heritage Collections, University of Edinburgh. Reproduced with permission. © 2015 University of Edinburgh.

represented as padding (see especially [Figures 1–3](#), nos 1, 3, 5). The appearance of early thirteenth-century Western knights was clumsy due to the heavily padded undergarment worn beneath their chain mail, the earliest type of medieval metal armour.⁴³ This padded

⁴³ Stephen V. Grancsay, 'The Mutual Influence of Costume and Armor: A Study of Specimens in the Metropolitan Museum of Art', *Metropolitan Museum Studies* 3 (1931), 194–201, at 194.

garment was made from quilted fabric ‘stuffed with cotton or other material’. It served as further protection, and when chain mail was removed, the padded garment or robe was the main civil dress for contemporary knights.⁴⁴ In the fourteenth century, the knights’ costume was modified with the development of plate armour, with their undergarment evolving into a tight-fitting dress.⁴⁵ The soft armour made of linen and fabric was assembled with steel plates covering brocaded and embroidered fabric.⁴⁶ Military costumes not only showed the knights’ power and force, but also reflected contemporary fashion, showing their slim beauty and taste for bright colours influenced by contemporary daily dress.⁴⁷ In contrast, Mongolian robes were made of silk and their armour was totally covered by lamellas. The padded garment worn by the Mongols in Altichiero’s frescoes seems therefore to derive from western knights’ costume, rather than from actual Mongolian armour.

It is unlikely that Altichiero had direct contact with Mongolian merchants and ambassadors, or with anyone wearing their national attire. While he did represent the Mongolian-style robe, matching William of Rubruck and John of Plano Carpini’s descriptions, he also created his own military fashion. The style of the robe matches the verbal description, but it has subtle differences from extant objects. The braided waist belt has been replaced by thin or wide belts, and the collar depicted in the fresco is round rather than covered. The awkward heaviness of the padded fabric has been lessened by combining it with the long robe, narrow sleeves and tight belt on the waist. This draws on the contemporary aesthetic of western knights showing their slim bodies. However, Altichiero did not select the updated, most functional western armour for Mongols, namely iron plate armour covering a short, tight surcoat or decorated with embroidered fabric. The long, padded garment worn under chain mail as knight’s civil dress was old-fashioned by the late fourteenth century, but the padding was still used as military costume. This choice perhaps created a sense of chronological distance for contemporary audiences familiar with armour. This sense of distance might be transferred to the Mongols

⁴⁴ Stephen V. Grancsay, ‘The Interrelationships of Costume and Armor’, *Metropolitan Museum Studies* 8 (1950), 176–88, at 177.

⁴⁵ Ibid. 178.

⁴⁶ Ibid. 179.

⁴⁷ Ibid. 178; Grancsay, ‘Mutual Influence’, 194.

as coming from a distant country. By adapting the bright colour and style of the robe in the frescoes, Altichiero also fashioned it to accord with contemporary military fashion, with the bright yellow and red of the robes recalling contemporary descriptions of knights' colourful attire in historical romances.⁴⁸ The padded fabric on the Mongolian-style robe distinguishes the Mongols from other knights in the frescoes and is presumably in accordance with the patrons' own tastes in fashion. The combination shapes an imaginary and fashionable costume for the Mongols, but also relies on a realistic knowledge of Mongols themselves. In addition, when this padded robe is associated with the hanging swords at the waist (Figures 2, 3, nos 3, 5), it may have signified an implicit identity of Mongols to the patrons. They might not have been intended as just ordinary witnesses, that is, civilians, but as foreign warriors. In contrast with wheel-pommel swords equipped by European knights and short swords carried by civilians in the fourteenth century, the curved swords hanging on the Mongol's belts are entirely distinct.⁴⁹ Both European and Muslim troops used straight iron swords in the Crusading period,⁵⁰ while Mongol soldiers used curved swords, which were regarded as 'formidable and efficient'.⁵¹ Gong Zhao emphasized the light and curved features of swords utilized by Mongol soldiers.⁵² These hanging swords would have highlighted the figures' Mongol identity, while also presenting them to audiences as eastern knights. The patrons of San Giorgio, the Lupi, were themselves knights and undisputedly acquainted with armour and weapons. Simone Lupi, nephew of Raimondino, had educated Francesco il Novello, heir of the Carrara family, in arms and chivalry in 1359 and 1360.⁵³ For these patrons,

⁴⁸ Grancsay, 'Interrelationships', 178.

⁴⁹ For more details about medieval knight swords and short swords, see Ada Bruhn Hoffmeyer, 'From Mediaeval Swords to Renaissance Rapier', *Gladius* 2 (1963), 5–68, at 53–66; Stephen V. Grancsay, 'Early Short Sword', *Bulletin of the Metropolitan Museum of Art* 28 (1933), 138–9; Helmut Nickel, 'A Crusader's Sword: Concerning the Effigy of Jean d'Alluye', *Metropolitan Museum Journal* 29 (1991), 123–8.

⁵⁰ Carole Hillenbrand, *The Crusade: Islamic Perspective* (London, 2017), 453. Blades from China and India were highly regarded.

⁵¹ Robert W. Reid, 'Mongolian Weaponry in "The Secret History of the Mongols"', *Mongolian Studies* 15 (1992), 85–95, at 88.

⁵² '刀甚轻薄而弯' ('The knife is highly light, thin and curved'): Gong Zhao, *The Mongolian Chronicle*, 30; author's own translation.

⁵³ Benjamin G. Kohl, *Padua under the Carrara, 1318–1405* (London and Baltimore, MD, 1998), 133.

the Mongolian figures could be understood as eastern knights, albeit wearing civic clothing. Additionally, these eastern knight figures might have reminded the patrons of those Mongols invading eastern Europe in the later thirteenth and early fourteenth centuries.⁵⁴ In his testament of 13 July 1385, Bonifacio Lupi, the supervisor of the fresco project, commented that he was over seventy years old, indicating that he had been born some time before 1315.⁵⁵ Lack of direct documentary evidence makes it difficult to determine whether Lupi was aware of the 1348 incursion, which took place in eastern Europe and far from northern Italy, and did not cause the same level of panic as earlier Mongol invasions. His understanding was more likely shaped by the collective memory of earlier invasions, which might have already entered western European discourse before his birth and continued to circulate through chronicles and oral transmission.⁵⁶ Before 1315, the *Chronica Major* (c.1236–50, MS 16II) of Matthew Paris (c.1200–59) had illuminated and described images of Mongols as cannibalistic monsters. The Hungarian illuminated chronicle *Chronicon Pictum* (1358) also recorded two Mongolian invasions of Hungary. It is possible that Bonifacio's memory was shaped by these chronicles and artistic depictions, or by family narratives relating to Mongols. Medieval mnemonic practices often relied on architectural spaces and visual imagery to aid recollection.⁵⁷ Within this framework, distinctive physiognomy, curved swords, and unique attire could serve as mnemonic triggers evoking association with Mongols. Meanwhile, the frescoes also functioned as a visual record, conveying visual information on the Mongols to audiences when the Oratory was open to the public. The frescoes could therefore have played a part in cultural memory-making.

⁵⁴ The Mongols attacked the Mačva region (present-day Serbia) in 1291–2, perhaps operating from Bulgaria or Serbia, and carried out further incursions into Hungary and Slovakia, including an attack on Leles in Zemplén (present-day Slovakia) in 1305. Poland also suffered a Mongol raid at Sandomir in 1293. While the Mongols attacked Hungary again around 1348, they did not launch as frequent large-scale invasions of eastern Europe between 1310 and 1340 as they had between 1250 and 1300. During this period (1310–40), there were minor disturbances, but these lack clear historical documentation. For more detail, see Peter Jackson, *The Mongols and the West 1221–1410* (New York, 2018), 172–4.

⁵⁵ P. Enrico Lombardi, *Messer Bonifacio Lupi da Parma e la sua Fondazione in via San Gallo in Firenze* (Firenze, 1992), 41.

⁵⁶ Mary Carruthers, *The Book of Memory* (Cambridge, 2014), 153–4.

⁵⁷ *Ibid.* 154.

MONGOLS AS RELIGIOUS AND POLITICAL PROPAGANDA

Although the participation of Franciscan friars in the decoration of San Giorgio is less documented, it is improbable that the artist would depict pagans and the threat to Christendom without consultation with, or permission from, both the friars and the patrons. To understand their involvement, the following section considers these depicted Mongols at the intersection of Franciscan missionary concerns, the political activities of the Lupi family, and papal-Mongol relations in fourteenth-century Padua.

Beyond artistic expression, the placement of Mongols in the religious narrative may indicate a geographic inference. As noted above, two distinct Mongolian figures (Figure 3, nos 5, 6) appear in the *Adoration of the Magi*. The Magi are usually depicted as arriving from the East to visit Christ in Bethlehem, having first travelled to Jerusalem.⁵⁸ Altichiero's representation of Mongols might suggest that the scene occurred in Central Asia, as well as highlighting the Eastern provenance of the Magi. In the *Adoration of the Magi*, apart from the castles in the right background, which correspond to the *Golden Legend's* description of Jerusalem as 'the royal city', the Mongols serve as the main visual clue linking the scene to the East.⁵⁹ In reality, Jerusalem and Bethlehem were under Mamluk rule in the late fourteenth century.⁶⁰ The Mamluk sultan exchanged slaves as gifts with the Golden Horde, and free people from the Golden Horde voluntarily became slaves to acquire political power; thus, Mongols could be present in these cities.⁶¹ Francesco Petrararch, in his *Itinerary to the Sepulcher of Our Lord Jesus Christ* (1358), mentioned Jerusalem alongside Jaffa and Acre, providing a tangible eastern spatial direction that might have informed Altichiero.⁶² A similar rationale may explain the Mongols' presence in accounts of the martyrdom of St George. According to the *Golden Legend*, one version recounted that St George's martyrdom took place in a Persian city, Dyaspolis, while in another version he suffered under

⁵⁸ Voragine, *Golden Legend*, 79–82.

⁵⁹ Ibid. 79.

⁶⁰ Katherina Galor, *The Archaeology of Jerusalem: from the Origins to the Ottomans* (New Haven, CT, 2013), 209–31.

⁶¹ Barker, 'Black Sea Slave Trade', 84, 95.

⁶² *Petrarch's Guide to the Holy Land*, ed. and transl. Theodore J. Cachey (Notre Dame, IN, 2002), unpaginated (§16.0).

the Persian emperor Dacian.⁶³ In the early thirteenth century, the Mongols had conquered eastern Persia, and in the fourteenth century, Persia was under the control of the Mongols.⁶⁴ The representation of the Mongols could therefore show contemporary knowledge of the Mongol-controlled region in the fourteenth century, serving as an eastern visual sign, rather than a specific historical site.

In contrast, the presence of Mongols in the *Martyrdom of St Catherine* is less indicative of geographic location. Their appearance there and in the *Crucifixion of Christ* as indifferent bystanders might suggest a symbolic rather than a geographic rationale. Notably, one Mongol (Figure 2, no. 2) raises his left arm as if responding to the divine presence descending from the angel or in the breaking of the wheel, echoing the *Golden Legend*'s description, on which Catherine prayed for the destruction of the wooden wheels and the conversion of those standing nearby.⁶⁵ This figure's placement corresponds to that of the potential converts described in the text. This representation can be considered in the broader context of Franciscan missionary activities. Six popes in the fourteenth century 'extend[ed] the purview of Latin Christianity' to Mongol Eurasia through measures including preaching and papal treaties.⁶⁶ The Mongols might have resonated with Franciscans' persistent appointments to despatch missionaries to the Yuan Dynasty to achieve their dream of 'universal Christendom' in the far East in the late thirteenth and fourteenth centuries.⁶⁷ However, there is no direct evidence that Altichiero intended to position the Mongol as a potential convert to Christianity within this Franciscan oratory. The depiction might also indicate contemporary Franciscan engagement with missions to the East. In this reading, the frescoes can be considered within a broader Eurasian horizon, without asserting a definitive symbolic meaning.

Finally, given their involvement as patrons, the activities of the Lupi family and the political context of the frescoes deserve attention. In July 1356, the Paduan lord Francesco il Vecchio da Carrara (1325–93)

⁶³ Voragine, *Golden Legend*, 238. Voragine provided several versions of the location and ruler in his account of the martyrdom of St George.

⁶⁴ Roxann Prazniak, *Sudden Appearances: The Mongol Turn in Commerce, Belief, and Art* (Honolulu, HI, 2019), 229.

⁶⁵ Voragine, *Golden Legend*, 724.

⁶⁶ Ibid. 303.

⁶⁷ Geraldine Heng, *The Invention of Race in the European Middle Ages* (Cambridge, 2018), 320.

extended his friendship to King Louis of Hungary (1326–83), who supported Padua in the wars against Venice in 1372 and 1373.⁶⁸ Bonifacio Lupi, as a knight, served on the war council of the Carrara regime in 1372 and acted as ambassador to Hungary in the same year.⁶⁹ The Lupi family joined the inner circle of the Carrara after Bonifacio returned from Hungary with the military cooperation of the king.⁷⁰ King Louis, as a long-term ally of Padua, provided both financial and military support for Padua's wars with Venice in 1372 and 1378.⁷¹ Bonifacio's military activities were closely connected with the campaigns of the king of Hungary. In July 1372, on returning from Hungary, Bonifacio commanded Hungarian troops.⁷² In June 1378, Paduans-Hungarians initiated an armed conflict with Venice.⁷³ Bonifacio, as one of the Paduan lord's ambassadors, participated in the negotiation for peace with Venice on 8 June 1380 with the Hungarian ambassadors.⁷⁴ In addition, a Hungarian marble relief (1487) records one of King Louis's victories, which may have occurred in his war between the Turks and Bulgarians in Wallachia in 1375.⁷⁵ Two years later, the king wrote a letter to Francesco il Vecchio declaring his victory over the Bulgarians.⁷⁶ All this reveals that Bonifacio had close contact with the king of Hungary, who himself was in direct contact with the Mongols.

For nearly a century, Christendom and the Mongols experienced a dynamic interplay of peace and conflict. The Mongols were not always a threat. In the late thirteenth century, the Mongol Ilkhan of Persia sought alliance with the papacy against Turks and Mamluks.⁷⁷ On 4 April 1275, Pope Nicholas III despatched the Franciscan mission to the Ilkhan Abagha of Persia, seeking a potential alliance

⁶⁸ Kohl, *Padua*, 103, 122–3.

⁶⁹ Ibid. 173, 178. See Table 6.3, 'Members of the War Council of July 1372', in *ibid.* 173.

⁷⁰ Ibid. 178.

⁷¹ Ibid. 207.

⁷² Richards, *Altichiero*, 154.

⁷³ Kohl, *Padua*, 207.

⁷⁴ Ibid. 217.

⁷⁵ Charles Zika, 'The Treasury Image of Mariazell: The Materialisation of Hope, Assurance and Security', *Emotions: History, Culture, Society* 7 (2023), 52–75, at 56–7.

⁷⁶ Richards, *Altichiero*, 155.

⁷⁷ Kenneth M. Setton, *The Papacy and the Levant, 1204–1571*, 4 vols (Philadelphia, PA, 1976), 1: 146–7. The Il-Khan Arghun (1284–91) sent a reconciliatory letter to Pope Honorius IV on 18 May 1285 and sent the ambassador Rabban Sauma to the pope in 1287.

with the Mongols against Islam.⁷⁸ The Mongol envoys received generous hospitality in Rome and were allowed to attend religious celebrations and other events. In the early fourteenth century, successive popes attempted to establish ties with the Mongol Khans against Islamic enemies. In 1307, Clement V expressed optimism about the Ilkhan's potential to restore the Holy Land to the West, while in 1305 the Golden Horde Khan wrote to the French king seeking peace.⁷⁹ In 1313, Clement V despatched seven bishops to Cathay after receiving a letter from Brother Giovanni who was conducting missions in its capital.⁸⁰ However, the peace between the eastern European countries and the Golden Horde did not last long, though the pope tried to intervene. In 1340, Benedict XII sought reconciliation to ease the conflict between Hungary and the Golden Horde.⁸¹ From 1348 to 1352, Mongols attacked Hungary several times, but King Louis had the force to resist.⁸² By the late fourteenth century, the conflicts declined and papal commendations praised Hungarian kings for their resistance.⁸³ From about 1354, under the policy of King Louis, Hungary's territorial conflicts turned southwards, clashing with the Ottoman Turks.⁸⁴ The 'anti-Mongol crusade' in eastern European countries waned after the decline of the Golden Horde.⁸⁵ Yet, the connections and diplomatic relationships between the Mongols and the popes did not end abruptly. In 1370, Urban V (1362–70) despatched friar William of Prato as archbishop to Cathay, but the

⁷⁸ For the letter of Nicholas III, see *ibid.* 1: 133 n. 46. Nicholas III also attempted to seek cooperation with Kubilai Khan in Beijing.

⁷⁹ Jackson, *Mongols*, 209.

⁸⁰ Aziz S. Atiya, *The Crusade in the Later Middle Ages*, 2nd edn (New York, 1965; first publ. 1938), 251. These were Andrea of Perugia, Peregrine of Castello, Niccolò of Apulia, Guillaume de France, Pietro of Castello, Andrutius of Assisi and one Brother Gerard: see *ibid.* 251 n. 3.

⁸¹ Jackson, *Mongols*, 182. Benedict XII wrote a letter to the Golden Horde Khan Özbek (1282–1341) that he wished to carry out missionary activities in his dominions; he later made compensation for the damage caused by the Hungarian and Polish kings.

⁸² *Ibid.* 181.

⁸³ Jackson comments: 'It is true that John XXII called Carobert an "athlete of Christ"; that for Benedict XII he was striving to be a wall of defence (*murum defensionis*) for Christian peoples; that Innocent VI, granting King Louis a tenth in 1356 for the war against the papacy's local opponents in Italy, would praise him for having kept the Tartars at bay; and that Clement VI awarded Louis any lands he might wrest from pagans or schismatics.' *Ibid.* 182.

⁸⁴ *Ibid.* 180.

⁸⁵ The Golden Horde had begun to decline from 1347. It continued to disintegrate over the course of the fifteenth century and was finally destroyed in 1502.

Ming Dynasty banned entry to all foreign religions approved by the Yuan Dynasty.⁸⁶ Urban's action may not have been only about eastward missionary efforts. In March 1363, he convened a meeting with King John II of France and Peter I of Cyprus, announcing a crusade setting out on 1 March 1365 to respond to the attacks of the Turks.⁸⁷ He also urged King Louis to offer the support of his Hungarian troops.⁸⁸ He was eager to facilitate the crusade against the Turks and made considerable efforts to do so. In 1369, Urban wrote to 'kings and other magnates' urging them to support the emperor in recovering Christian lands which the Turks had occupied.⁸⁹ It may not have been a coincidence that one year later, he despatched missionaries to Cathay. This was no sudden diplomatic manoeuvre. The papacy had attempted to cooperate with the Mongols against their common Islamic enemy in the early fourteenth century. When Pope Urban V was endeavouring to seek allies against Turks, the previous pope's intended cooperation with the Mongols would have served as a pertinent reminder.

Within this context, Altichiero accepted the commission from Raimondino. Only four years before Altichiero received the commission for San Giorgio, Bonifacio Lupi's ally, Louis I of Hungary, won a victory over the Turks. As Richards has argued, 'the crusading themes, the chivalric material, the interpenetration of contemporary life with that of a historical or mythical past, all these are common elements which had already shaped the course of Altichiero's career.'⁹⁰ In light of these events, the date of the commission and the increased Mongolian figures in San Giorgio, it could be argued that the Mongols in the San Giorgio frescoes symbolized both the patrons and the Franciscan friars' political and religious propaganda. Firstly, the depiction of Mongolian warriors watching the martyrdom of saints as neutral bystanders could weaken the tension and hostility between Christians and Mongols. Secondly, if I am correct in interpreting the Mongols' robes as the civilian dress of knights equipped with swords, this attire could convey to audiences, especially chivalric family members, that these Mongols had military power. As noted earlier, the patrons must have been well acquainted with this dress. However, the visualized

⁸⁶ René Grousset, *The Empire of the Steppes: A History of Central Asia* (New Brunswick, 1970), 319.

⁸⁷ Setton, *Papacy*, 244–5.

⁸⁸ *Ibid.* 251 n. 135.

⁸⁹ *Ibid.* 313.

⁹⁰ Richards, *Altichiero*, 155.

force of the armed Mongols was not directed against Christians. The Mongols were watching, rather than being engaged in violence, and there is probably a suggestion that Mongols might be converted, in which case, their military power could also be used to Christian ends. All this suggests that the representation of the Mongols could put into pictures the prospect that Mongols could be potential allies of the Holy See or Christendom in the fight against the Turks.

CONCLUSION

This article has examined the image of the armed Mongols in relation to the Lupi family's military and political engagements, Franciscan missions to the East, and later medieval papal-Mongol diplomacy. Altichiero represented the Mongols through distinctive physiognomy and costume, combining his knowledge, visual experience, and imagination of the Mongols with elements of Western armour to create a hybrid image of the Mongol in San Giorgio. Within the contemporary historical and political context of Padua, these figures could evoke both geographic association with the East and the potential of the Mongol as an ally against the Turks. Yet Paduan attitudes towards Mongols were complex, and this remains a subject for further study.⁹¹ The Mongols in San Giorgio served not only as a reminder of a distant land, but also as a means of placing medieval Padua within a Eurasian framework.

⁹¹ In my doctoral thesis, 'Collective Imaginary of Cathay in the Visual Culture of North Italy in the Fourteenth and Fifteenth Centuries', I examine different perspectives on Mongols.